

EUROPEAN SUBMACHINE-GUNS (1915–38)

Although trench warfare during World War I involved static lines facing each other, night-time raids across “No Man’s Land” were frequent. Intended to probe weak points or to secure prisoners for interrogation, the taking of an enemy trench was fraught with danger. Limited manoeuvrability restricted the use of rifles and most actions were fought hand-to-hand. To counter this, arms designers developed submachine-guns—reduced-length, fully-automatic weapons using pistol cartridges. The choice of ammunition made the submachine-gun an intrinsically short-range weapon, but it was ideal for close-quarters trench conditions. Submachine-guns continued to be significant up to the eve of the next world war.

▼ BERGMANN MP18/I

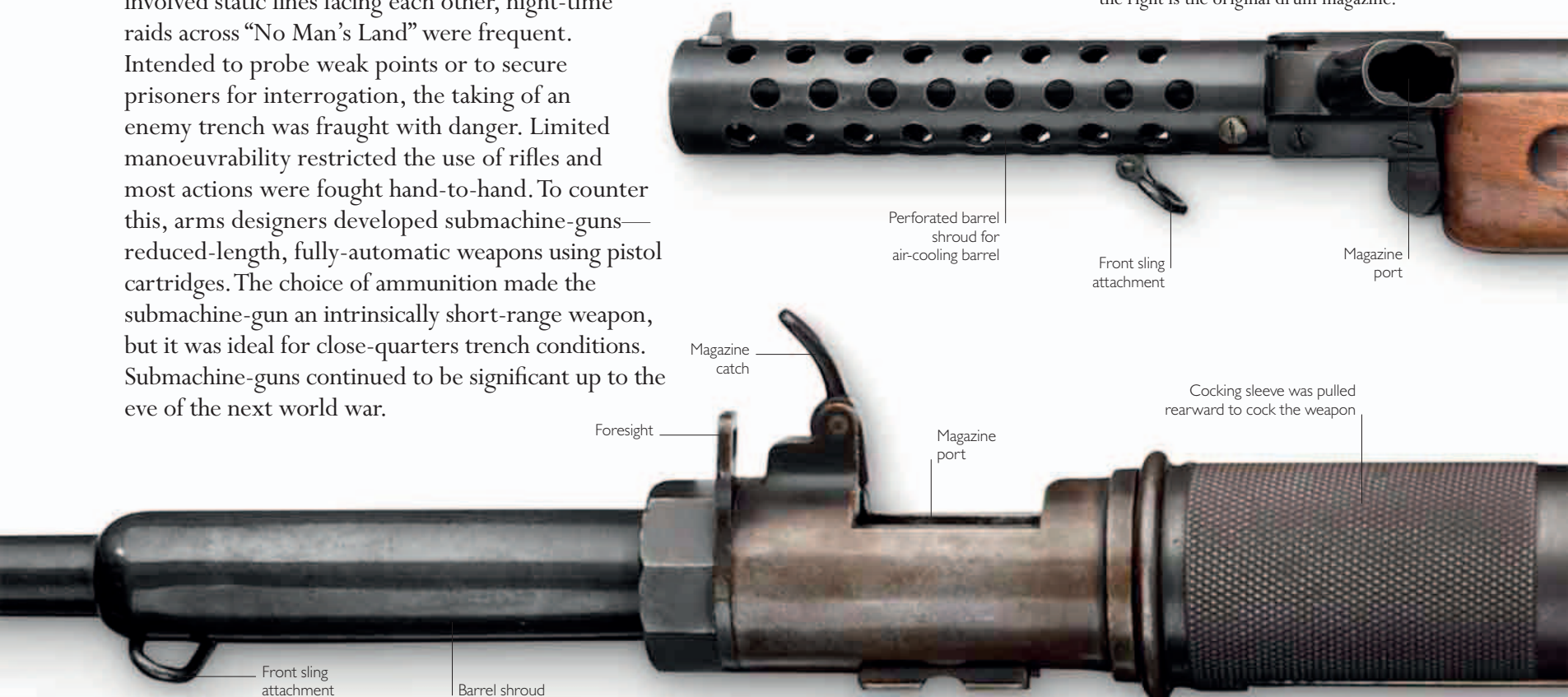
Date 1918

Origin Germany

Barrel 7½in (19.6cm)

Caliber 9mm Parabellum

The strong, sturdy MP18/1 was the first effective *maschinen-pistole* (machine-pistol—the German name for a submachine-gun). It was chambered for the Parabellum round Luger had developed for the P.08 pistol (pp.170–71), although that resulted in feed problems until a simpler box magazine was designed. Shown to the right is the original drum magazine.



▲ VILLAR PEROSA M1918

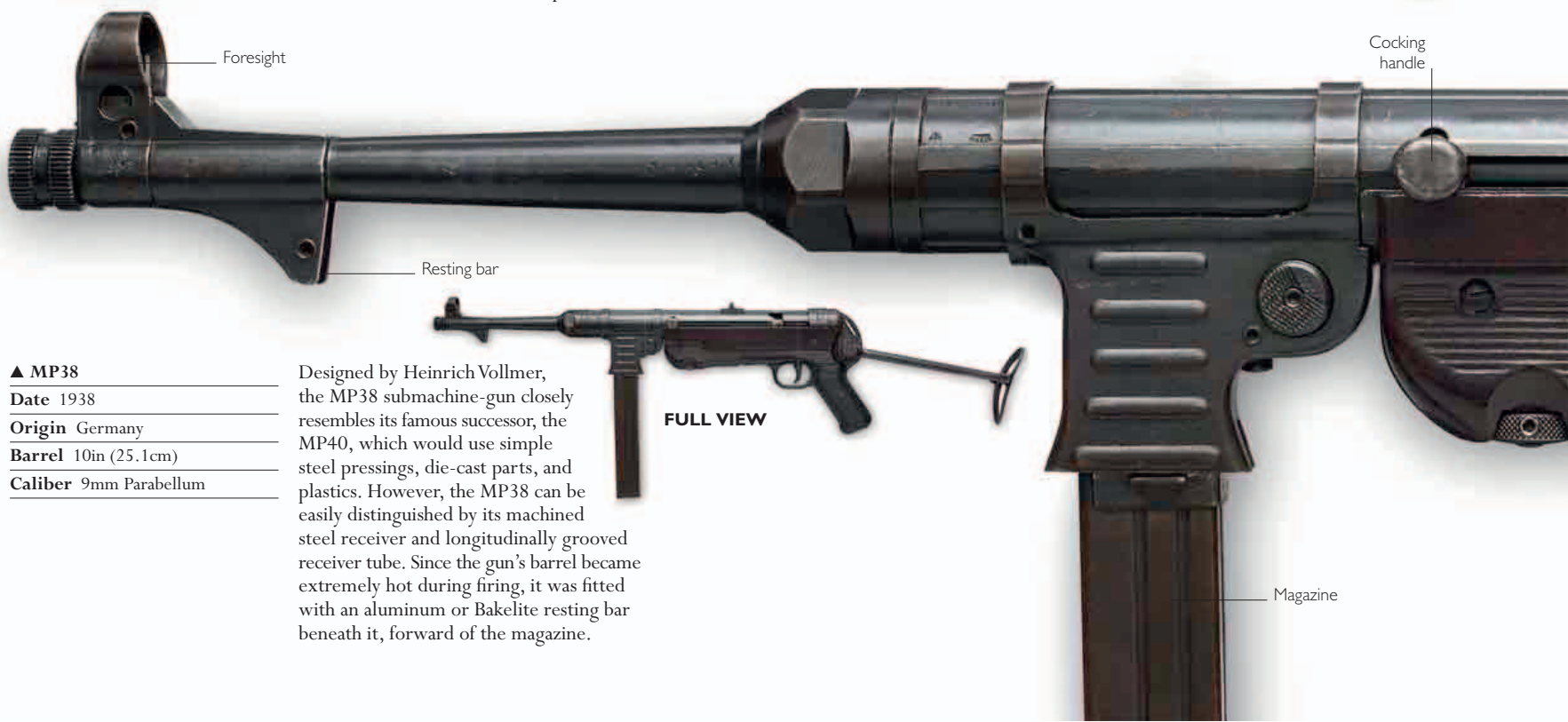
Date 1918

Origin Italy

Barrel 11in (28cm)

Caliber 9mm Glisenti

This gun had an extremely high rate of fire—900 rounds per minute—and was equipped with two triggers: a burst-fire trigger for a fully automatic mode and a single-shot trigger for a semiautomatic mode. This model is a variant of the M1915 Villar Perosa, the first ever submachine-gun (SMG), which was issued to Italian troops in 1915.



▲ MP38

Date 1938

Origin Germany

Barrel 10in (25.1cm)

Caliber 9mm Parabellum

Designed by Heinrich Vollmer, the MP38 submachine-gun closely resembles its famous successor, the MP40, which would use simple steel pressings, die-cast parts, and plastics. However, the MP38 can be easily distinguished by its machined steel receiver and longitudinally grooved receiver tube. Since the gun's barrel became extremely hot during firing, it was fitted with an aluminum or Bakelite resting bar beneath it, forward of the magazine.